Nikhil Kamath x Ranbir Kapoor | People by WTF Ep #2

[Speaker 2] (0:18 - 1:12)

As an entrepreneur, we speak mostly to young wannabe 20-year-old boys and girls who want to start a business, to be desirable from the lens of getting funding, to be wanted. I think that innate quality, I feel like you do it very well. You want to be able to teach a young guy or girl how to emulate that.

Hi Ranbir, how's it going?

[Speaker 1] (1:14 - 1:52)

Nervous, excited. You know, over the years I've heard so much about you, about your achievements and all of that. But I was on reels one day on Instagram and I came across this one reel of yours, where you spoke about, was it detachment, indifference?

Detachment. Detachment. And it was something which really resonated with me because I felt like, okay, that's something that I connected with.

It's not something that I probably believe also, but it's not something that I could say it openly. I was very afraid to say something like that. And I think that really kind of, I felt you there.

You know, so I got very excited to speak to you. I'm really happy to be on the show.

[Speaker 2] (1:52 - 1:58)

And I looked for a bunch of interviews of yours. For some reason, you never do one more than 20 minutes.

[Speaker 1] (1:58 - 3:00)

No. Because that's the thing, right? When you're promoting a film, that's the only time you give interviews.

It's so film-centric and sometimes it's, I think the relationship of film actors with Indian media and especially entertainment media is a bit shaky. It's because you start talking to them before the film is released. And people are not really interested in knowing about the film as much as they're interested in your personal life, as much as at one time it was my marriage and it was Raha, then it was how it's fatherhood.

So that's what stands out, you know. So I think a lot of actors and film people realize that interviews is not the way to go to promote a film. You have something inspiring to say, then do an interview.

And that's what I believe in. Because when you talk, you're inspiring. You're inspiring people.

You're sharing your own experiences. If you don't have anything to share, I'm not interested in talking about myself. I'm not interested in talking about my achievements or my personal achievements.

But something like this is stimulating. It's stimulating for me. It's inspiring for me.

And I hope like with this conversation, we can inspire somebody, you know, some experience. Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (3:00 - 3:20)

I have a lot of curiosity around our conversations that day. And I genuinely wanted to get to know you more. So I have no questions for today.

Perfect. I'll set context and say, I don't know too much about Bollywood. So I wouldn't ask you too many questions about a movie or Bollywood or this.

[Speaker 1] (3:20 - 3:20)

Great.

[Speaker 2] (3:23 - 4:31)

And there is one nuance that I am very interested in. We all project and we depict a version of ourselves to the world. But as an entrepreneur, we speak mostly to young wannabe, 20 year old boys and girls who want to start a business, who want to build something for themselves.

To be desirable from the lens of getting funding, to be wanted, to be in a room and have people be interested in you, I think that innate quality is inculcated by many people. But I feel like you do it very well. So if we can arrive beginning at your childhood up until now and try and figure out how you got to be this way.

How when you interact with people, you leave them a bit interested, you leave them intrigued. Nobody knows too much about your life. You want to be able to teach a young guy or girl how to emulate that.

If we can capture that somewhere along our catch up, that'd be quite interesting.

[Speaker 1] (4:31 - 4:34)

So I'm supposed to like speak about monologue right now?

[Speaker 2] (4:34 - 4:41)

No, no, no monologue. You tell me a part of your life, childhood. I'll tell you a part of mine.

[Speaker 1] (4:41 - 4:43)

So we can go back and forth. Why don't you start?

[Speaker 2] (4:43 - 4:44)

Yeah, sure.

[Speaker 1] (4:44 - 4:51)

I mean, I know everything from you joining a call center till now. So anything before that is something I'm interested in.

[Speaker 2] (4:52 - 5:15)

Yeah. Born in Shimoga in Karnataka. Dad worked in Canberra Bank.

So he got transferred typically once every three years. Moved from Shimoga to Hassan again in Karnataka. Then went to Haryana, lived in a place called Karnal for three years.

Great experiences. Still have some friends from Karnal.

[Speaker 1] (5:16 - 5:17)

You finished your school in there?

[Speaker 2] (5:17 - 6:41)

I stayed in Karnal till I was about six or seven, I would like to say. Then came to Bangalore. Then when my dad got transferred beyond that, we didn't travel with him.

But we stayed in Bangalore with my mother and my mother's family was here. In Bangalore, my grandmother, her brother. Yeah, when she was alive, they were all in Bangalore.

And from the age of seven till 37, for the last 30 years, I've been pretty much a Bangalore boy. Have immense love for the city, which has in a way given me everything. And I think it's a two way love.

I showcase it a lot. And I think the city continues to love me. Hence, I was telling you the other day, you should come to Bangalore and hang out.

It's very different from Mumbai. Not in the way that you typically hear from people that Mumbai is fast, that city is slow. One city is flashy, another is not.

Not in such an obvious way, but in a very nuanced way, I think every city is different. And

Bangalore has a soul which is different from Mumbai's soul. And I feel like you have to be there to experience it.

Yes, okay. You do you.

[Speaker 1] (6:42 - 7:10)

It's coming back to my childhood. So I was born to Rishi Kapoor and Neetu Singh, who are actors. I am four generation in my family of actors.

I grew up in a privileged household. I went to Bombay Scottish school. I was not really good at studies.

Because very early on, I realized to become an actor, you don't need to study. So I used that to my advantage.

[Speaker 2] (7:11 - 7:12)

How did you know you want to be an actor?

[Speaker 1] (7:13 - 7:52)

I don't think I ever, there was a day where I said, yeah, I want to be an actor. I think because you are a star kid. So there is so much of attention.

The thing is, in school, if you get attention from a girl, you feel like, oh, I can be an actor. I mean, it starts there, you know, the confidence comes in. Then being from the family that I come from, it was taken for granted.

But I, like, I remember when I used to do like dramatics in school. I was not really good. I was not, I was never selected.

I was an introvert. I still am. I was very good at football.

So football gave me a purpose. It gave me a sense of, okay, I'm decent at something. I was below average in everything.

[Speaker 2] (7:54 - 7:56)

Did you get treated specially in school?

[Speaker 1] (7:57 - 8:03)

Not specially, no. I got beaten up by everybody. The teachers, the principal.

I remember one day I was crawling out of class.

[Speaker 2] (8:03 - 8:05)

We're about the same age, no?

[Speaker 1] (8:05 - 9:19)

I'm 41. 82 born. Similar.

Yeah. But I was in a, like, convent school. So, like, they were very strict.

They used to hit us with canes and, like, dusters on the knuckles and all of that. So I've gone through all of that. And being a naughty kid and because they thought that I was the celebrity kid and I was going out of control, they used to kind of pick on me a little bit more.

Having said that, no, I don't want to, like, bitch about my teachers and principal because I really had a good time in school. I went to Bombay Scottish. It's a school in Mahim.

Then I went to HR college. I got 54.3 in my 10 standard boards. And when I got that, I was in New York because my father was directing a movie called Aap Loi Chale.

And when my mother was in Mumbai and when she heard of the result, she called us. I haven't seen happiness in my family's face as what, like, what I witnessed. When they heard that I got 54.3, they thought, like, nobody had passed my family. The seventh dropout, eighth dropout, ninth dropout. So, like, they really thought, okay, this guy can achieve something in life. I did a little bit of assisting on a film called Aap Loi Chale, which didn't work.

My father directed that film. Realized that my father's a terrific actor, but he's not that good a director because he doesn't have a temperament to be a director. He's very short tempered.

[Speaker 2] (9:19 - 9:20)

What is a director's temperament?

[Speaker 1] (9:20 - 11:46)

It's very hard, because you are basically, it's such a selfless job, a good director. You know, you're doing everybody's job, but giving them the credit for it. You know, you are the boss on set.

And any decision is your decision. Like, they'll come to you, even for like a color or like lensing or lighting or performance. Everything's up to you.

So, it's kind of you playing God in a way. So, anyways, my father was not cut out for that. I went to HR college in Mumbai.

Never saw a classroom. Just had dosa outside and went. And the pool bug had hit everyone,

right?

Snooker and pool and bowling. There was a very cool place called The Bowling Company, which had opened in Mumbai. And that was a haunt.

I have so, all my, the two years of my college life I've spent there. Then I went to New York. I went to a film school called School of Visual Arts.

I didn't score very good in my SATs. So, I didn't get into NYU, USC or UCLA. So, I got into this school, SVA, which is pretty good.

It's a graphic design school. That's what they specialize in. So, did direction there.

I realized that my passion was growing more towards direction than acting. Made a lot of short films, which I'm very embarrassed about. But got an understanding of how movies are made.

But it's only after I came back to Mumbai, after I dropped out of, it was an undergrad course. Before the undergrad course, I finished all my film classes. Didn't take humanity and science classes.

Dropped out. Because I said, what will I do with a degree? I just needed to get some experience in film.

So, I dropped out. I came back. My father said, I'm too young.

And I suddenly started getting a lot of attention from directors and people and media. And said, go back to America. Spend a year, do something useful that could help you.

So, I enrolled myself at the Lee Strasberg Theatre Institute. That's popular, right? I've heard of it.

It's popular. They teach you the method. I'm not a really big fan of the method.

But I think by then, I was very eager to come back and start work. I felt like, okay, I'd got the experience of America. It was not really the college experience.

But just the experience of the exposure. You know, just interacting with students from all over the world. Living alone.

My father kept me on a very tight budget. Just to give you an example. Of course, when I say tight budget, I'm still coming from a privileged background.

But it was enough that I could have a McDonald's dollar menu meal for lunch and dinner. So, it was like $2 lunch, $2 dinner. It was as strict as that.

Even though I come from a privileged background, this was...

[Speaker 2] (11:46 - 11:47)

Why do you think that is?

[Speaker 1] (11:47 - 11:54)

He's never addressed this or spoken to me about it. But he really wanted me to like live like a student and not live like somebody who's...

[Speaker 2] (11:54 - 11:55)

Why do you think rich parents do that?

[Speaker 1] (11:57 - 12:17)

I don't know. Teach you value for money. Even when I came back and I started assisting Mr. Bansali on a film called Black. I was an assistant director. He took away my car. So, I had to travel in public transport.

I was not getting any pocket money. So, I think he really wanted to school me in a way that, this is not life. You know, you're too moisturized.

You need to really see what hardship is.

[Speaker 2] (12:17 - 12:21)

Do you think they do that for you or for themselves to show that they are doing it?

[Speaker 1] (12:23 - 12:50)

So, the thing is having a child and now since I have a child, I also question that. That if I'm doing something, am I doing it because it's making me happy and because I feel this is good for her or it's for her. So, that question I'll never be able to answer, you know.

But I do feel that my father was... He was a short-tempered man, but he was a very good man. You know, he's somebody who really loved his family, loved his work, loved his food, loved his alcohol.

You know, he was a very open person. He, whatever he said, he could speak about it.

[Speaker 2] (12:51 - 12:54)

Did you think of him that way from the very beginning? Like growing up one to ten?

[Speaker 1] (12:54 - 13:00)

I, Nikhil, never saw his eye color. I was always like this. I was just like, yes.

I never said no. You know, I was so scared.

[Speaker 2] (13:00 - 13:05)

Like the movie Animal. I watched it. It was really good.

Animal, I was more obsessed with him.

[Speaker 1] (13:05 - 13:58)

Here, I was scared of my dad. You know, like he never shouted at us. He never raised his hand.

But just because around us, his temperament was so like volatile, that it always scared me. So, anybody who speaks in a louder tone from childhood, it started disturbing. My parents went through like shit loads of like fights.

You know, we live in a bungalow. So, I've spent like most of my childhood on the staircases hearing them fight. So, I was always a little scared.

And I was always on the edge. But I think both of them were going through a very rough patch. They both loved each other.

And eventually, they found beautiful companionship. You know, when my father was suffering cancer and he was abroad. And I saw the kind of selfless service that my mother was doing for him.

And that kind of love was something which I probably at that time wouldn't have imagined.

[Speaker 2] (13:59 - 14:03)

And in these confrontations, did you try and stop it? Or did you partake in any manner?

[Speaker 1] (14:03 - 14:27)

Of course, many a times. And the thing is, it also happened when my sister just left for her further education. So, she was not around.

So, I kind of felt responsible. And my mother really used to talk to me a lot about her feelings. My father was not an expressive person.

So, I never understood or heard his point of view. What was the issue? What was going on?

[Speaker 2] (14:27 - 14:29)

Why do you think he was the way he was?

[Speaker 1] (14:31 - 14:55)

I think that generation of men are scared of vulnerability. Yeah, like, even to express his love to me, he never could hold my hand. He could hug me, but his hug had a...

You know, it wasn't a hug. Maybe I'm blaming it that it's that generation, but I don't know. You know, he just was very distant.

I knew he loved me a lot. He cared a lot for me.

[Speaker 2] (14:55 - 15:09)

Do you think the movies of the time define how very subconsciously the men of that generation want to be? Like, do you think the movies of your father's time, subconsciously made him who he is? Who he was?

[Speaker 1] (15:12 - 16:45)

I think that's how India was also, no? At that time. Art imitates life.

Life imitates art. That goes on year by year. But I think back then, the kind of movies my father was doing...

See, it was a way more forgiving audience. Cinema was like a very big medium and it was, apart from cricket, it was the only source of entertainment at that time. So you could be doing five films a year on the same subject.

The same story. You know, Lost and Found. It was the same thing.

But they were just doing the same stuff. So they were very forgiving. In today's day and age, they're not forgiving.

When you speak about a film like Animal, Animal became a huge success. But I remember when I was offered the film and the first time I heard the story, I got very scared. I got very scared because I'm also kind of being...

Following a career path where I'm doing good roles and, you know, trying to give good social messages. You know, not trying to do stuff which I kind of play the good boy, basically. You know, coming of age, that romantic image that I had.

So I found this very bold. I found this very... adulterated.

I found this something which I was very scared that maybe the audience would not accept me.

And let me tell you, when the film was released, even though it did amazing numbers and did really well and we got a lot of love, there is a big audience which found this film misogynist and found this film wrong in some way.

[Speaker 2] (16:45 - 17:02)

I'm not saying this because you're sitting here. I feel like... I'll get into a little bit of trouble maybe for saying this.

But how can somebody be okay admiring Godfather where a gangster is killing 20 people? And that is okay.

[Speaker 1] (17:03 - 17:03)

His own brother.

[Speaker 2] (17:04 - 17:16)

Yeah. But this is not okay. I don't think movies should be where society derives their sense of morality.

Movie is a medium of entertainment, right? And you're portraying a story and doing it in the best manner.

[Speaker 1] (17:16 - 18:10)

That was the intention. But I think it was misconstrued. And I think social media also played havoc.

You know, they need something to talk about. So they really went to town with claiming what a misogynist. What happens is that you know the hard work that you put in.

And I know that this director also made a film called Kabir Singh which also faced the same thing. It just gets diminished. There's a lot of hard work, a lot of good intentions that went behind it.

But because it suddenly gets this tag which is not true, the perception that you were talking about stayed with this film. So Anima, though if you go to general public and they speak very fondly about the film. But there are many people who I meet who are like, you shouldn't have done this film and we're so disappointed in you.

A lot of people from the film industry. So I just quietly apologize. I say, sorry, I won't do it next time.

I don't really agree with them. But I'm in that phase in my life that I really don't argue with anybody. And if you don't like my work, I'll say, sorry, I'll try harder next time.

[Speaker 2] (18:11 - 18:13)

If you had to do it all over again, would you?

[Speaker 1] (18:13 - 18:50)

100%. The kind of… See, I was kind of stagnating and hitting a saturation point in my career.

I was called the next superstar for a very long time. And I'm not saying I'm a superstar today. Unless you don't have that continuous blockbuster films, you can't be called a superstar.

But I think Anima, what it did is it was the correct film at the right time to kind of just at least take another step up. Otherwise, I've been kind of flatline in the same status. So that was very important for me for my confidence.

It was very important for me to kind of change, you know, shift from a boy to a man in some ways.

[Speaker 2] (18:50 - 18:53)

Going back to childhood, sister, how is that relationship?

[Speaker 1] (18:54 - 19:53)

Sister is two years elder to me. I love her. We shared a room together till I was in the seventh grade.

So I was 13 and she was 15. She used to beat me up first because she was bigger than me. She was a bit chubby.

But when I grew in size, then I used to beat her. Do all the WWF stunts with her. But then she got…

The thing is, she left for further education to London. By the time she came back, I went to New York. By the time I finished and came back, she got married.

So, you know, I missed out on the good years of bonding with her. She's married in Delhi. She has a beautiful 13-year-old daughter.

Her name is Samara. I love my brother-in-law. Great, super guy.

I don't know if you've ever met him. His name is Bharat. So she's happy.

She's in a good space. I'm happy for her. But I'm not as close to her as I would like to be.

Again, it goes back to that indifferent detachment. I've always been that person.

[Speaker 2] (19:53 - 19:55)

You think you're that avoidant detached?

[Speaker 1] (19:55 - 21:16)

I think so. Always. And this is not something that I became after I became a working professional.

I was like this at a very young age. I think I have this faint memory. I don't know which friend this was.

But I think when I was like four or five, whenever this friend used to leave home after playing with me, it used to really burn inside. Like something used to break. And I think maybe I just closed up.

And I just detached myself from that. Maybe it was that. Maybe I was born that way.

I don't know. But I do have memory of feeling a lot of pain when that person was going away. But having said that, now that I am a father and I have a daughter, that's a game changer.

So that is making me question detachment and indifference. Because I feel like I was just born. You know, like I was reborn right now.

So the 40 years of my life that I've lived was another life. This is another life which is starting. So feeling a lot of new kind of emotions, a lot of new kind of feelings are creeping in.

New thoughts. I never feared death. I always said that I would die at the age of 71 because I had this obsession with the number eight.

I don't know why I said that. I don't want to sound cool or what. But now I'm like, that's too soon.

That's like another 30 years. I want to live at least for 40 more years. So all that has changed a bit now because I have a daughter.

[Speaker 2] (21:17 - 21:20)

What's that feeling? See, I don't know it of having a child.

[Speaker 1] (21:20 - 21:23)

Will you get married though? I asked you and you said no.

[Speaker 2] (21:23 - 21:27)

No intent of I don't see myself getting married or having kids.

[Speaker 1] (21:27 - 21:31)

What if somebody just sweeps you off your feet and you just fall head over heels in love?

[Speaker 2] (21:31 - 21:32)

We had this conversation.

[Speaker 1] (21:32 - 21:34)

I know, but let the people need to hear this.

[Speaker 2] (21:37 - 22:06)

Like my t-shirt today says, transient, that word means a lot to me. Why is that? I feel like I have changed as a person every year in the last 10 years.

What I thought I wanted today has been totally different from what I wanted the next year. And I would hate to commit the present version of myself to another person when I know I'm going to change so much.

[Speaker 1] (22:06 - 22:19)

I have two questions for you. Let me ask the second question first. So when you're 70, paint a picture, like how do you want your life to be?

Apart from your professional achievements.

[Speaker 2] (22:19 - 22:30)

No, I think about this all the time. I have friends. You know, this lady from Biocon, Kiran.

We live in the same apartment. We hang out a lot.

[Speaker 1] (22:30 - 22:32)

She's also part of your giving.

[Speaker 2] (22:32 - 23:40)

Yeah, she's part of the giving pledge. But she's 70, doesn't have kids. Husband passed away last year.

And I keep asking her, are you lonely? Are you this way? Are you that way?

How do you feel about this? How do you feel about that? I really admire her for so many things, but she seems very fulfilled in life.

I don't think she is lacking one particular thing that she would have had if she had kids. She's a very complete person. I love how she's able to be a lot more altruistic in life, even versus if she were to have had her own kids.

It's good for society. It's good in a society with up and down to have somebody with a really high moral compass and altruism by virtue of their situation in life. It kind of negates some of the bad in society.

I feel like I wouldn't hate myself if I was 70 and in her place. She's exactly 70. It was her 70th birthday last year.

[Speaker 1] (23:40 - 23:46)

Would you be as open and giving as her at that age? I would be. You would be?

Would you still be working?

[Speaker 2] (23:47 - 24:02)

I think so. I feel like I enjoy having something to do every day. I have at times, even when I have three, four days off, and I have no work, I don't feel happy about it.

I feel like...

[Speaker 1] (24:03 - 24:04)

Do you have any other passions? Any other passions?

[Speaker 2] (24:05 - 24:05)

Outside of work?

[Speaker 1] (24:07 - 24:08)

Sport or a hobby?

[Speaker 2] (24:08 - 24:16)

Yeah, I play badminton sometimes. I used to play football. I go to the gym once in a while.

I read some books.

[Speaker 1] (24:17 - 24:20)

Once in a while, as in you have a trainer, you have a program or you just go because you just feel like...

[Speaker 2] (24:20 - 24:32)

No, no, I have a trainer who I've had for a long time. He's more like my social interaction of the day in Bangalore. So in Bangalore, I don't particularly, or in Bombay, I don't go out, go out as such.

[Speaker 1] (24:33 - 24:38)

So you're talking about three things. You were at 70, sports, hobby, and will you retire? I want to know these three things.

[Speaker 2] (24:38 - 25:06)

Retirement, I don't know. It's not very appealing to me. I'm like, retire and do what?

If I had this passion in life that I have not been able to give time to and I can go into that, maybe retire, but I don't have such a thing. I've not found anything. I would be very insecure if I didn't have to go to work for a long time because I find a lot of my validation from my work.

[Speaker 1] (25:07 - 25:19)

And when you say work, it's not the companies where you're investing or what you have. It could be something new, right? Like you're not married to just the things that you're doing right now.

No, no, not at all. Like you like to try new things, new businesses. Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (25:20 - 25:31)

But I'm not as composed as, you know, I sometimes project to be. I'm always looking for validation in the small things in life and the big things in life.

[Speaker 1] (25:31 - 25:33)

Validation from whom? Success.

[Speaker 2] (25:34 - 25:53)

Validation to me is, there is no person who is validating me. It's somehow my own subconscious validating my conscious side. Don't get me wrong.

I care a lot about what people think and what my friends and my peers and colleagues and all. And I do care for what they think of me.

[Speaker 1] (25:53 - 25:54)

But that's not your inspiration.

[Speaker 2] (25:54 - 26:05)

Yeah, but deep down it is. It's like going to the gym, right? Like if you go to the gym and workout, who are you really validating?

Maybe it's your ego. Maybe it's your subconscious.

[Speaker 1] (26:06 - 26:22)

When you go to the gym, you feel good about yourself, which is a healthier lifestyle, confidence, you know, that kind of, it has a result. But I'm saying, but if you're working, are you working because you want to be more successful, more rich? You want people to admire you.

What gets you off?

[Speaker 2] (26:24 - 27:17)

Eventually, I feel like in society, everybody is chasing status, which is differentiation from your fellow people. It has been that way from the very beginning. When there were hunters, you wanted to be the strongest hunter.

When you were farmers, you wanted it. When you were in the era of capitalism, you wanted it. When you were in the era of religion, you wanted that.

You wanted to maybe be the Pope or high up in that hierarchy. So like everybody else, I am chasing status. The definition of what...

And you haven't achieved it yet, you feel? I don't think anybody ever achieves status. So it's an ongoing process.

Like you look at some of these really great people who write books while they're alive, right? Like take Marcus Aurelius, people who ruled the world and wrote while they were ruling the world.

[Speaker 1] (27:18 - 27:19)

You like Marcus's writing?

[Speaker 2] (27:19 - 27:46)

Yeah, I like a couple of his books. He talks about how what he had didn't matter while he was alive, which is unlike somebody in his position. I've not been able to do that in the manner that he has.

I still... Attached. I'm still attached.

While pretending to be detached and also being convinced of being detached myself a lot of the

time.

[Speaker 1] (27:47 - 27:48)

It's also so true.

[Speaker 2] (27:48 - 28:06)

Yeah, but coming back to you. So sister, mother, father covered. What happened HR college time?

How did... Did everybody know pre going to New York to the film school that you're going to be an actor?

[Speaker 1] (28:06 - 28:35)

Yeah, I knew who I was, especially like, you know, you get pointed out a lot. He's Rishi Kapoor's son. You know all of that.

So you get attention. But because I'm an introvert, so I was always running away from it. New people means new expectations, new friends.

I started smoking cigarettes, which became a very nasty habit for from the age of 17 till last year when I finally quit.

[Speaker 2] (28:36 - 28:38)

How did you manage that?

[Speaker 1] (28:38 - 29:03)

When I became a father, I started feeling very unhealthy. So yeah, HR college reminds me of smoking because it was the first time I bought a cigarette packet. You know, you share with your friends and you smoke outside and you feel grown up and all of that.

First time that you're wearing your own clothes, you know, wearing a school uniform. I've always been a fashion guy. Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (29:03 - 29:04)

You're starting a sneaker brand.

[Speaker 1] (29:05 - 29:59)

You know, Nikhil, I've been talking about this actually for many years, for actually 10 years. I've been a sneaker head since I was a kid, into basketball and baseball and American sports. Used

to travel a lot to New York.

So I'm very passionate about it, but I'm being scared because I'm scared is because I don't know India as well as I should. I don't know the market. I always question it that how come you don't have a Zara and H&M?

How come you don't have something with such a big consumer market? How come you don't have that? So yeah, I am planning to start a brand.

It's been a couple of years that I'm working on it. A lifestyle brand, Essentials. Something which…

Streetwear. I think streetwear is a bit bastardized now. So I think I would like to call it Essentials.

Like what a white t-shirt should be like, what jeans should be like, what a white shirt should be like. And of course, sneakers is because I love sneakers.

[Speaker 2] (30:01 - 30:03)

Who are your favorite sneaker brands?

[Speaker 1] (30:03 - 30:20)

Always an Air Jordan brand. I like the three, the white cement the most. The collaborations are good.

So an Air Jordan. I know sneakers have also hit a roadblock right now. Especially the Jordans and the Yeezys.

So somebody has to come up with something new.

[Speaker 2] (30:21 - 30:22)

The prices are dropping now, right?

[Speaker 1] (30:23 - 31:16)

Majorly, majorly. So yeah, I'm learning. I don't want to…

I just don't want to be this… I don't like this word but the celebrity brand which tried and failed. So many of them have failed.

Having said that, my wife is a very successful owner of a brand. She started a toddler and children wear brand called Edamama. And it happened in front of my eyes and she was just amazing.

The fact that she chose to do something like this and she worked through lockdown and I saw the

marketing genius that she was. I don't think I'm a marketing genius. I do have an idea and a dream and a vision but I'm still trying to do the groundwork.

You know, just study the market, meet people. I met really interesting people about their experiences. So yeah, I'm still learning.

What do you feel though about this whole…

[Speaker 2] (31:17 - 31:52)

I feel like Indian celebrities shy away from being vocal about who they are as people. They show the very media trained facet of them and I feel like that worked five years ago. I don't know if it works today because you can't fall in love with a face or the manner in which a person acts or the proper image that they project.

I think people fall in love with the flaws. People fall in love with the vulnerabilities and so then is it like…

[Speaker 1] (31:52 - 32:41)

I'm taking advice from you because I'm an actor and I've always tried to stay away. I've always tried to create a little bit of a mysterious aura because I'm a film actor and I did realize very early on that if I was on social media also people would get bored of me because I'm there for them to message and abuse me or say I love you or I'm on endorsements and film marketing and my films are releasing. It'd be too much of me.

So then where is the mystery? But if I try and control my narrative that okay this is Ranbir and this is who I am, this is who I like. Will the media or the audience will they like that vanilla version even though it sounds vanilla or they want to create something which seems this guy is a celebrity so let's make it more spicy?

[Speaker 2] (32:42 - 33:24)

I feel like if the real version of you with the flaws, the vulnerabilities, the strength, all of that is depicted in a manner which is truly organic to you I would assume like there will be some people who will troll you and dislike you and all of that but net net if you then sell sneakers I think more will sell. I personally believe that because when you're buying George Clooney's tequila what are you really buying? You're buying, yeah, right?

Because I mean there's no differentiation in the product beyond a point. So beyond childhood okay we established you had avoidant attachment a bit like me.

[Speaker 1] (33:24 - 33:24)

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (33:24 - 33:29)

Hate confrontation to a certain extent. Great relationship with sister.

[Speaker 1] (33:31 - 36:48)

Great relationship with my mother. Not so great with my father distant but loved and respected him. Stopped crying very early on and I just stopped crying.

Yeah, that's my childhood. You know for me I didn't cry when my father passed away. I know that when the doctor told me the night that I was in the hospital spending the night there I stayed there for quite some time and he said that this is his last night and he's going to go anytime soon.

I remember I went up to the room and I got a panic attack because I don't know how to express myself. I didn't know what was happening. There's too much to take but I don't think I've grieved.

I don't think I've understood the loss. I mean losing one of your parents is a very big moment. Do you feel guilt?

I feel guilt as much as guilt as he felt while he was going away because that one year that we spent together in New York while his treatment was on he often spoke about that. You know he one day I was there for like 45 days stretch and he came to my room and he just started crying and he's never showed that kind of weakness to me and it was so awkward for me because I didn't know if I should go hold him I should hug him and I really realized the distance and I felt I feel guilty that I didn't have the grace to let go of the distance or the glass between us and go and hug him or give him some love.

So I have guilt for that. Yeah also you've been brought up saying that now you're responsible and this and that certain things that play in your mind I have a mother, a sister, a wife, a child and my father passes away can I show my weakness? I don't know what it is but I just didn't cry and I have tried therapy before my father got sick in London and I don't think therapy worked for me for two reasons firstly because I don't think I could completely honestly express myself to the therapist maybe I wasn't someone who I connected with and secondly I realized that the therapist in some way was teaching me how to manipulate life.

Explain. In a way that it became okay if this is say a conflict with a friend so there is a certain way there is a method that you can overcome this problem by doing certain things and whatever he was telling me about say relationships or life it made me realize that I don't want to manipulate life and I don't want to put something in motion to avoid it because it gives me peace or it doesn't stress me out. Again maybe it was a bad therapist or maybe I didn't gel with the therapist but that didn't work for me.

I'm often told by a lot of my friends and my near ones to try therapy is because I don't express

myself I don't cry so I have nothing against therapy it's just that I have to open myself up and I'm very scared of opening myself up. But if you are also an introvert how did you do it?

[Speaker 2] (36:50 - 36:57)

When I went to her or whenever I go to therapy I go usually like once in a week or once in every two weeks.

[Speaker 1] (36:57 - 37:03)

But do you go to therapy thinking like it's gym for the mind or do you go to therapy because you have something that you want to unlock?

[Speaker 2] (37:04 - 37:05)

I feel like it makes me more efficient.

[Speaker 1] (37:06 - 37:07)

So it's basically going gym for the mind?

[Speaker 2] (37:07 - 37:55)

I feel like it makes me perform better even at work. There's often things that sit in my head and I make them bigger than they actually are and somehow she puts it in context. I say it myself and these people put it in context like same example guilt right?

This is something I deal with all the time. My dad passed away recently like three months ago and abruptly like we were not expecting it. The emotion that I dealt with right after that and even up until today is I can't look at his picture because then I start thinking we didn't live in the same house.

I started living alone when I was 17, 18 years old.

[Speaker 1] (37:55 - 37:56)

He's obviously seen your success.

[Speaker 2] (37:57 - 37:57)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (37:57 - 37:58)

He's super proud of you.

[Speaker 2] (37:58 - 38:52)

We're a loving relationship like never had an altercation very supportive but we didn't spend a lot of time together. I would go visit him once in a week, once in two weeks, once in a month. The guilt of not having done enough as a son and it also so happened that when he passed away because it happened abruptly I was not here.

I was traveling. It's a weird experience though. I was in Dubai on the way to a work meeting somewhere else and when I got the call from the hospital my mom said we're rushing him to the hospital and just before I boarded the flight back to Bangalore the doctor told me he's not making it.

Like just, actually I boarded and just before taking off.

[Speaker 1] (38:53 - 38:54)

It's a three hour flight to Bangalore?

[Speaker 2] (38:55 - 39:01)

Three hour, three and a half hour flight to Bangalore and then you land in Bangalore. There's traffic and then you take…

[Speaker 1] (39:01 - 39:03)

By the time you landed he was still alive?

[Speaker 2] (39:03 - 39:43)

No, no, no. He was gone. He was gone while I was on the flight and the doctor told me that they were not able to revive him.

But the guilt started becoming exponentially bigger from that point. Why am I not there? He was there for me when I was a kid.

He was there for me when this, when that, when all of that. That's not logical, no, this guilt? It's not logical but it's there.

It's not logical but it's there. Why did I not take him on that holiday? Why did I not do a bunch of things which just make me feel guilty?

Why was I not nicer to him? Why did I not go to that one function, one puja where he wanted to take me in his hometown in Udupi?

[Speaker 1] (39:44 - 39:47)

You think your brother was a better son? He's elder, right?

[Speaker 2] (39:47 - 41:49)

He's elder, he's older but he had an even worse experience because he was in Thailand at that point and… He was not in town? He was not in town and he could not get there for a day and a half.

So, when we were sitting with the body, right? And he took a day and a half, he was trying frantically to come back but he just couldn't and there were no flights and the fastest one he took and he did all of that. I think he felt a lot of guilt himself too.

I don't think he expressed it but these are small things which blow up like after he passed away, we did, you know, there are so many prayers, right? Hindu-Brahmin family, like every day, there were prayers for 3-4 hours in the morning. You go to a river, you go to this temple, you go to that temple.

Day 13 of my dad passing away which was 3 months ago, somewhere in Jan. Day 13, we went to 8 temples in one day in Udupi, in his hometown. We said we will go to the last 13th day in his hometown.

We did that, came back to Bangalore Day 15, brother has a stroke. And then back to the hospital and while brother has a stroke, sister-in-law, so we're a tiny family, father, mother, brother, his wife and their one kid. While Nitin has a stroke on the 15th day, his wife is in Dubai getting treated for cancer.

She had stage 3 cancer. What's happening, man? I know, it's crazy, right?

The sequence of events is ridiculous. And because she's getting treated for cancer, she's bandaged up and they've done something. Doctor's not letting her fly back.

And Nitin has had this. So, I'm in the hospital then again with Nitin for 3-4 days. I think his guilt, I don't know how much of a part it played in his stroke.

[Speaker 1] (41:50 - 41:51)

Has to be something.

[Speaker 2] (41:51 - 41:52)

Yeah, but these are all such...

[Speaker 1] (41:52 - 41:53)

It's too coincidental, yeah.

[Speaker 2] (41:53 - 42:07)

Yeah, these are all such tiny, tiny events in a sequence. It feels like all of our lives we believe are in the world out here but they're actually in our head. So, guilt is a big thing.

[Speaker 1] (42:07 - 42:22)

What's your relationship with God? You went to these temples because your father would have liked it. Yeah.

Not because you wanted to. Okay, let me rephrase that. But when you're at the temple, what's your communication?

[Speaker 2] (42:25 - 42:30)

At that point, wherever dad is, let him be happy. Pray for that.

[Speaker 1] (42:30 - 42:32)

So, you are speaking to somebody?

[Speaker 2] (42:33 - 42:33)

You are speaking to somebody.

[Speaker 1] (42:33 - 42:34)

You believe that you're speaking to somebody?

[Speaker 2] (42:34 - 42:34)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (42:35 - 42:35)

So, you believe in God?

[Speaker 2] (42:36 - 43:04)

I don't know. This is a very fluid thing in my head. At times when I've been asked this question, I've said, I don't know.

At times I've said, yes. Like many others like myself, I am guilty of using it as a crutch. When something drastically bad or good happens in my life, I suddenly have a belief in God.

And when life is…

[Speaker 1] (43:04 - 43:05)

So, you don't thank God. You're not grateful.

[Speaker 2] (43:06 - 43:20)

When something good happens, I'm very grateful. Like when something very bad or very good is happening. I feel like I have three versions of answers for this.

I feel like I have a cynical answer. I have a stoic answer. I have an optimistic answer.

[Speaker 1] (43:20 - 43:23)

You believe in all three of them? Yeah. It's all of them.

[Speaker 2] (43:24 - 43:26)

Yeah. You tell me yours and give me a minute to think.

[Speaker 1] (43:27 - 46:14)

So, I grew up… My father was extremely pious. He used to do two pujas a day.

We used to celebrate Diwali with a puja. We have Ganesh at home for five days. Ganesh in RK Studios for 10 days.

We celebrate every festival. We have Navratras at home where we grow the Kheti and Mata. So, God was a very big thing growing up.

And I think it made my… It gave a lot of peace to my father. My mother was less religious.

Less than my dad. But it made him happy. So, she used to do it.

So, we as kids saw them. Like you said, kids see their parents and try and emulate that. So, I have a good feeling about God.

I don't have a… I've never… You know, I realized very early on that my manifestation power is very strong.

If I ask something from God, I was getting it too easily. So, at a very young age, I stopped asking. Because I said, I'll save it for a rainy day.

You know. And I was very young when I was having this conversation with myself. But I think since then, I…

Every night, I say, Thank you, God. And I go to sleep. So, I've never ever asked God for

something.

Even when I'm in trouble. Even when like my mother's fighting with me and I don't have another conflicted conversation with her. But she's going to cry and stuff like that.

Or I want a film to succeed. Or I want to buy something. I've never asked for that.

So, my relationship with God is a lot of gratitude. And you know, I feel very, very grateful for the place I'm in. Of everything that I have.

And so, that kind of sums up my relationship with God. I started believing a lot in the Sanatan Dharam. I think I started reading a lot about it in the last couple of years.

I went quite deep into what it is, what the effects are. And see, you believe it or you don't believe it. If you believe it, it's like hope.

It's like giving yourself a good system. You know, good values. Now, you could teach a child.

I'm giving an example of my child. I could teach her values that I have kind of made up with my experiences. Or I can teach her the values of what we all know.

What God wants or expects us from. And I think there's something good about it. You know, I feel, when I sit for puja, I feel connected.

I feel there's some connection. I feel good about myself, the good energies. I do yoga, chanting every day for an hour.

And when I'm hearing the mantras that my Guru is reciting, I feel good. You know, I believe it. So, I believe in God.

[Speaker 2] (46:15 - 47:12)

I feel I have been so lucky in life that it's unlikely if somebody did not like me. But in organized religion, I find the hypocrisy so much that I don't know what to think about that. Like, I'll give you an example.

I go to temple sometimes. Whoever can afford it or some popular person or whatever who comes there. Cuts the line, goes in, people are waiting.

Like, I just don't... It doesn't sit... The entire thing doesn't sit well with me.

I'm like, what is it? Because somebody has paid more money, they get access. Somebody wise said this.

Whatever is higher in your list of beliefs in that hierarchy is your God.

[Speaker 1] (47:13 - 47:16)

Yes. Yeah, so... So then who's your God then?

[Speaker 2] (47:16 - 47:24)

I'm trying to think of my list of beliefs. Work. My mom, my mother was a music teacher.

Her music is God.

[Speaker 1] (47:24 - 47:25)

What's yours?

[Speaker 2] (47:26 - 47:26)

Thinking.

[Speaker 1] (47:27 - 47:32)

You can say it's work. Work is worship also. So I'm sitting on that.

[Speaker 2] (47:33 - 47:45)

I don't know if work is it. I don't know. Interesting concept though.

I have to like really...

[Speaker 1] (47:45 - 47:47)

Have you ever spoken about God in any of your podcasts?

[Speaker 2] (47:47 - 47:50)

No, no. I haven't spoken about all of this in any of my podcasts.

[Speaker 1] (47:50 - 47:52)

Oh, really? Okay. Yeah, I've never...

[Speaker 2] (47:52 - 48:02)

Because it's always like a subject, right? We're talking about AI or this or that. This is more like life.

So I'm speaking a lot more about myself than I have ever.

[Speaker 1] (48:03 - 48:06)

What do you look up to? It doesn't have to be your family, anybody.

[Speaker 2] (48:07 - 48:59)

Yeah, so typically, see, I grew up where I had these spikes in my life, where things worked for me in different spikes. I feel like people who I considered my mentors on paper, when I was growing up, and I didn't have access to them, when I met them in person, and they became my friends, and I had access to them like I have today. You start seeing that they're a bit like yourself as well.

And you realize, okay, I saw this facet, which was exaggerated through that lens. But he has his own flaws, weaknesses, positives, advantages like me. So the mentor-mentee thing somehow doesn't appeal to me in the manner like it once did.

[Speaker 1] (49:00 - 49:05)

But I... Like have you met Warren Buffet? I have, yeah.

What do you feel about him?

[Speaker 2] (49:05 - 49:21)

No, no, I think brilliant. Like all of these people, Bill Gates, Warren Buffet, a lot of people, a lot of these people are brilliant in their own way. But would I want to be like them in every way?

I don't know. But there are facets of different people that I find appealing.

[Speaker 1] (49:22 - 49:23)

Yeah. Do you like Michael Jordan?

[Speaker 2] (49:24 - 49:25)

Yeah, I like Michael Jordan.

[Speaker 1] (49:26 - 49:26)

Do you like Messi or Ronaldo?

[Speaker 2] (49:27 - 49:32)

I like Messi. That's a very cliche thing to say because he seems like the nicer guy.

[Speaker 1] (49:32 - 49:42)

No, no, listen. I meet a lot of people who love Ronaldo. Really?

Of course, it's changed in the last one year post the World Cup. But it was quite 50-50 before the

World Cup.

[Speaker 2] (49:42 - 49:55)

Are you hungry? We'll eat also. Yeah, we can eat.

Harsh, can we eat also? Give us. Yeah.

What do you think is wrong with society today? If you had to paint them in your lens, what would you change? I think judgment.

[Speaker 1] (49:57 - 50:15)

It could be any order, but let me just start with judgment. I think people are too quick to judge. And I'm seeing it in my own family members.

You know, my own loved ones, my own friends. Very easy to judge, very easy to kind of pull someone down. Building on that.

[Speaker 2] (50:15 - 50:46)

I'll ask you a parallel question as well. What do you think of men's mental health today in society? There is a broad belief that men are not in society.

If there were 10 men, 10 women, 10 could go to war, 9 could die, 1 would come back and society would propagate. And it is not cool for men to play the victim card like it might be for women. What do you think that does to male psychology?

[Speaker 1] (50:49 - 51:25)

Well, you know, in the last few years, times have been a little... The thing is, you can't comment so freely on this topic anymore. You know, because somebody picks up something and that just becomes a trail of you being anti-feminist or being a male chauvinist.

So I just feel for anybody, if it's a man or a woman, if they're not well mentally, there's no shame in taking help. There is no shame in crying about it. And the people who love you will understand it.

And the people who don't understand it don't love you. So how does it matter? So it doesn't matter what people think.

[Speaker 2] (51:25 - 51:27)

Do you think it's harder for men today than it is for women?

[Speaker 1] (51:28 - 51:37)

It is harder for men today. You're saying regarding mental health. And to address it.

Yeah. 100%.

[Speaker 2] (51:37 - 51:44)

Not just address it, but they're worse off than women. If I were to grade society on the mental health scale of 1 to 10.

[Speaker 1] (51:45 - 52:02)

I don't know if it's worse for them. Listen, women in this country are also really oppressed. Like really oppressed.

And I see it in the city like Mumbai. So what happens in India, we don't even know. So it'd be very unfair to say that men are more oppressed.

[Speaker 2] (52:02 - 52:05)

And I think we're both a bit jaded by virtue of our surroundings.

[Speaker 1] (52:05 - 52:05)

Exactly.

[Speaker 2] (52:06 - 52:06)

Right?

[Speaker 1] (52:06 - 52:45)

Yeah, I would feel that. But I think I have close family members who are going through mental health problems. And they're very open about taking help, you know.

And my family is very supportive about them taking help. And I think mental health is something that it's nice to kind of tackle it also quietly. With a lot of grace and not really...

Don't use it as an excuse, you know. To not do things or not be a certain way. It's a problem.

Find a solution. Keep working at it. Take love and care.

But don't make it an excuse.

[Speaker 2] (52:45 - 52:45)

Right.

[Speaker 1] (52:46 - 52:47)

I think a lot of people make it an excuse.

[Speaker 2] (52:47 - 52:54)

Yeah. Play the victim card too easily. So what happened in life beyond New York?

We can go back there.

[Speaker 1] (52:56 - 55:12)

So Nikhil, I mean, you know, when I started, I was always regarded as this playboy guy who was just like dating actresses. And let me tell you, I was in New York for three years, nine months. I didn't date one girl.

I didn't go on one date. I was... What era was this?

This was from 2000 to 2003. Why? Because I made myself believe...

I've always been an aashik. So I made myself believe that my first girlfriend in school, when I left for New York, even though I was not with her, I made myself believe that that was my love of my life. Now it's over.

Now let's just focus on work. If things happen with her, it'll happen. But that's not...

And I think that mindset just made me not feel interested about anybody. Nobody. But yeah, when I came back and I started working, and then of course I dated two very successful actresses and that just became my identity.

That he's a Casanova. And I was labelled a cheater for a very large part of my life. I still am.

You know, it's one of those adjectives which pop up. Bothers you or don't care? No, I don't care.

It used to bother me because it's not really entirely true. People don't know the entire story. And I would never ever speak about somebody like this in public.

Because it's a very private thing. But things were spoken about me. And if it makes that person happy, I don't have any conflict with that person.

But it used to bother me when it used to bother my parents. So my parents used to open the papers and read about it. And they were like, what's happening?

So I don't think they also got bothered. I used to think that, okay, it's bothering them. So it's bothering me.

But eventually I realized that, listen, I am just a commodity. Now I'm accepted by the audience. People write good things about me, bad things about me.

It's now, it's just a commodity. It doesn't matter. So why am I taking myself so seriously?

There are millions of problems which are way more important than me feeling bad about being written about.

[Speaker 2] (55:14 - 55:21)

And you believe in, when you say romantic, you believe in one woman forever.

[Speaker 1] (55:21 - 55:49)

That's the only way, right? I mean, that's the only healthy way of living is because I wouldn't want my woman to be with somebody else. So I won't be able to accept that.

So it's only fair that that person expects the same from me. Yeah, but, yeah, so I don't want to hurt the person I love. I don't want to hurt Alia.

And I definitely don't want to hurt my daughter. So I will definitely not do anything which will ever make them question me.

[Speaker 2] (55:50 - 55:55)

And you're romantic for prolonged periods in life? I think so. I think, yeah.

What is romance to you?

[Speaker 1] (55:55 - 56:52)

How do you like? Watching a movie, laughing, chatting. You know, I'm so lucky, Nikhil, that I married somebody who I'm extremely close to as a friend.

Like we can really chat, laugh, bitch. You know, like she's my best friend. And I got really lucky with that.

How is Alia as a person? Alia is a wonderful person. She's somebody who is, she's got, she's very colorful.

She's 11 years younger to me. And when I met her, she, it's very funny. The first time I met Alia was when she was nine years old.

And I was 21, nine, I was 21, I was 20 years old. And we did a photo shoot together for a movie Sanjay Leela Bansali wanted to make called Balika Badhu about child marriage. So that's the first time I met her.

And it seems a little weird now.

[Speaker 2] (56:53 - 56:54)

You were already in movies at 21?

[Speaker 1] (56:54 - 57:28)

I was assisting Bansali on Black. Right. So yeah, he wanted to make a movie with me.

So he was dabbling in these different films. So I did a photo shoot with Alia. And I still, I have the photo shoot, I'll show it to you.

That's the first time I met her. But Alia was somebody who I met over the years. And I knew that this person is special.

I have immense respect for her as an actor, as an artist, as a person, as a daughter, as a sister. And she really makes me smile. You know, I'm very happy to go home to her.

I love going on a holiday with her. But I love coming home with her.

[Speaker 2] (57:28 - 57:30)

Is she in a good mood a lot of the times?

[Speaker 1] (57:31 - 59:10)

Well, she is a very ambitious girl. And she's a overachiever. Like work is, she's really passionate about her work.

Extremely passionate. Extremely intelligent. So yeah, she has spaces where she is kind of fragmented.

So you really have to get her attention. But I think over the years, me really cribbing to her about it, I have her attention. And I'm talking like she listens to me, you know.

But I think she's really made certain efforts. And I must acknowledge this about her is that everything I complained about or she complained about, I think she made better efforts than I have. She changed more for me than I have changed for her.

And I'm acknowledging it. But I should do something about it. So I should change a bit.

Change how? She, for example, used to speak in a very loud tone. And I think because of my father's tone, growing up, always kind of ratted.

So she really made efforts to kind of change that. And that's not easy when you live 30 years of

your life speaking a certain way. You know, she's someone who very instinctively react to if Raha falls down or she's like, you know, she's, there's a reaction.

Reaction. That kind of throws me off also, you know. So she makes certain things which put me at ease.

I hope I could say something that I did to put her at ease. I don't think I've done anything yet. I did bake a cake with Harsh once on her birthday.

Harsh, what year was that? What cake did we bake for her? Sorry, a milk cake.

Yes. Yeah. Not a big.

These were our coating honeymoon period years.

[Speaker 2] (59:11 - 59:13)

Have you been living together for a long time?

[Speaker 1] (59:13 - 59:16)

We've been living together since the first year that we started dating.

[Speaker 2] (59:16 - 59:17)

Which was how long ago?

[Speaker 1] (59:17 - 59:43)

This is 2018. We started working on a film called Brahmastra, which Ayaan made. The first thing we did on Brahmastra, we went to Tel Aviv to work with this movement coach called Ido Portal.

And on the plane is when we started our romance. So it was just that first day it was on. So yeah, romance for me is just hanging out with her.

So COVID was together? We were staying together. She lives alone, I live alone.

So it just made sense.

[Speaker 2] (59:43 - 59:48)

They say that much time with one person suddenly can change everything. Like what happened in COVID of living together?

[Speaker 1] (59:49 - 1:00:30)

Oh, it was the best time. I should not say it. But I really had a good time with Alia.

Like we were together for the entire lockdown. And I don't think we were frustrated with each other. We were being healthy.

We were training. We were playing online Catan. Do you play Catan?

We learned poker. So we had a good time. I think that really solidified our relationship.

And I think at the time when my father got sick, she was really there. She was there when I was in America. When I was in the hospital, if I was staying, she was staying with me.

So she's really done a lot for me.

[Speaker 2] (1:00:30 - 1:00:42)

Does that change? I hear so many people in marriages, how your partner is with your family is a game changer. I've heard this from so many people.

[Speaker 1] (1:00:43 - 1:01:32)

I think so, no? It's because you love your family. And another person who is an outsider is loving your family the way you love your family.

And that's something which, even if it's not real, even if it's an effort, it's still an effort. Because that kind of effort is not easy. You know?

And to continue doing it, it's very rare that everything just falls into place. Everyone just gets along. So it's always an effort.

My mother and Alia have a very good relationship. They're very honest with each other. More honest than I am with my mother, Alia is with my mother.

And that makes me very happy. Because I'm surrounded by women. My mother, my sister, my sister's daughter.

Now Alia, Raha. And they're just the best women in the world. It's a lot of female energy around.

[Speaker 2] (1:01:33 - 1:01:35)

Should we get the food and then continue?

[Speaker 1] (1:02:08 - 1:02:09)

Do you ever think of joining politics?

[Speaker 2] (1:02:10 - 1:02:10)

No.

[Speaker 1] (1:02:11 - 1:02:11)

Never?

[Speaker 2] (1:02:11 - 1:02:49)

Never. I feel like, you know, growing up, I've been a rebel without a cause kind of a thing. Politics requires for you to work in a certain structure.

And speak a certain narrative. Which you might or might not necessarily agree with. And I don't see myself being happy in that kind of a role.

I don't think so. That's actually the totally honest answer.

[Speaker 1] (1:02:49 - 1:02:56)

Do you think this could change after 10 years? The role? Or your perception about what you think you feel about politics?

[Speaker 2] (1:02:56 - 1:03:04)

Today, I don't think so. And I kind of like, I like my life. The version of my life that I'm living today.

[Speaker 1] (1:03:05 - 1:03:06)

That you created for yourself? Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:03:07 - 1:03:17)

Yeah. And I don't think I'm as badass as I would need to be for me to be a politician. Not today at least.

Would you?

[Speaker 1] (1:03:24 - 1:04:03)

No. I think I'm gonna, I would like to, I like the world of being an artist, creation. I like that.

I would like to die trying creating things. Direct movies. I know I'm not cut out to be a producer.

I tried producing one film called Jagga Jasoos. Which didn't do well at the box office at all. But I realized that it's a skill set which I don't have.

So it's very easy to say, you'll join politics, you'll do this. Because you're kind of successful in the field that you're in. But everything requires a skill set.

And I definitely don't have a skill. I'm not a people person. So I think in politics you have to be a people person.

Yeah. So I'm not that.

[Speaker 2] (1:04:04 - 1:04:17)

For the entrepreneurs watching and who want to be in your industry, what innate skill set does one need to be a producer, a director, an actor, or any of the other roles in there?

[Speaker 1] (1:04:18 - 1:04:21)

So each, this is an actor what it needs and producer what it needs?

[Speaker 2] (1:04:22 - 1:04:23)

One inherent trait.

[Speaker 1] (1:04:24 - 1:05:37)

I think in being a part of movies, two things which I've realized is very important is patience. Very important. A lot of people just want to just be successful.

And especially with social media, you know, that 15 minutes of fame and all of that. But to really have a long career in the arts, you have to have patience. You have to wait.

You have to have the quality of sacrifice. You know, you have to sacrifice something. Maybe your friendships or family life or a great lifestyle or travel.

Something that has to be sacrificed. Now, if I take the professions, to be a director, you have to be extremely selfless and giving. To be a producer, you have to be a people person.

I think a producer is somebody who could be a politician. Because he's really getting this 200 people together and giving them a belief that we're going to create this and inspiring them and making things happen. And as an actor, imagination, you know, childlike imagination, don't let that run out.

Don't become cynical.

[Speaker 2] (1:05:38 - 1:05:53)

And the question I ask you first, as a guy or a girl, how do you appear interesting in a room? How do you walk into a room, make an impression that leaves people wanting more?

[Speaker 1] (1:05:54 - 1:06:48)

You know, Nikhil, I've never had a problem with that because I don't want to be nobody noticed. I'm that guy. I am very happy if I'm not the most important person in the room.

The three other actors were getting more attention than me. I'm very happy as long as it doesn't come to me. I'm the guy that, you know, when people used to say roll number 28 and you have to say present Miss Ranbir here.

I used to stammer. Because I was like, each time I called Domino's pizza for a pizza and they asked me what's your name? I had to say Ranbir because I was so low on confidence.

So, my confidence has become better. But I'm very happy not being the center of attention. And a handsome is what a handsome does.

I mean, if your work is good, you know, if your intention is good, your work ethic, you know, that's what you need. What else do you need?

[Speaker 2] (1:06:49 - 1:06:51)

So, you finished college in New York and then?

[Speaker 1] (1:06:52 - 1:08:57)

Then I came back, like I said, my father said too much attention, go back, do something. You're too young. I was, must be like 2021.

Spent another year there, time to come back. When I came back, every director in the film industry wanted to launch me. But I was a big fan of Sanjay Leela Bansali.

And I'm like, every director wants to work with me. Why isn't Sanjay Leela Bansali offering me a movie? So, I was like, maybe he's not aware of me.

So, I went, made a resume and sat outside his office. Didn't tell him who I was. But when I waited, he was not there.

I left the resume, I went home. He called me the next day. And he, of course, reading my name, understood who I was.

And I told him I'm a big fan. Devdas had just released at that time. And I love Devdas.

I'm a big fan of that film. And the first day when he met me, he said that, I want to make a film with you. So, that was, ambition was achieved right there.

But that one year or one and a half years I spent assisting on Black with Mr. Bansali was actually the biggest film school of my life. Because A, he was a very hard taskmaster. We were working 14-15 hours a day.

We were, I, there were 10 other assistants. And because I was who I was, I was not some special kid. I was like everybody.

And he was, he was very short-tempered. So, we used to like face a lot of anger coming our way. And I think that really hardened me.

It really prepared me for anything in life. And then Savaria happened, which again was a very big disaster. And in hindsight, I also, I'm very grateful that it didn't do well.

Because that also prepared me for life, you know. So, these two setbacks starting on, of course, I was accepted as an actor. In a way that, okay, this guy has potential.

Maybe he'll do something. Then I had Bashna Haseeno, which kind of just played onto that image of me being a Casanova. Because the character was that.

But I think…

[Speaker 2] (1:08:57 - 1:08:57)

Is that a bad thing?

[Speaker 1] (1:08:58 - 1:10:47)

I feel like this Casanova thing really works. Well, it's not about good thing or bad thing. It's not the truth.

So, again, it was not a perception that I was playing or a PR game I was playing. It was just, I was a new young kid, right? Everybody was married and all the superstars.

And so, they had to kind of write about somebody. So, anyways, then I think the big film or the big moment of my life and my career was when I did a film called Wake Up Sid with Ayaan. It's the first time I met Ayaan.

But then I realized that… I remember on the third or fourth day, I've spoken about this a lot. But Ayaan came to me after three, four days of shoot and sat down and said that, you're ruining my film.

Because you're playing this part like a hero. And this is a character. And something just clicked, you know, like, okay.

Today in cinema, you can play a character. You don't need to always play the hero. You don't always have to play that quintessential hero.

And I think that really helped me in my next few years of the subjects I chose. My father was always against the films I was doing. He was like, what is this?

What are you doing behind the scenes? Wake Up Sid, Barfi, Rockstar, Rocket Singh. So, he was not a big fan of these films.

But… and I know where he came from, you know. He was like, listen, India is a very big country.

And Wake Up Sid is not going to reach India. It's going to reach your main cities, maximum. But if you really want to be a bona fide star of India, you want to be in more commercial movies.

But then I realized that whenever I tried a commercial movie, it never really worked out for me. It's because the intention was, let's do something bigger. The intention of believing in a story and character was always something which worked well for me and works well for anybody, actually.

Eventually, you'll only become a star or a superstar if you're a good actor. You know, if your work is good. So, I just focused on my work.

[Speaker 2] (1:10:48 - 1:10:50)

Which movie was your dad proud of?

[Speaker 1] (1:10:51 - 1:12:10)

I think the first movie he was proud of was two movies. One was Ajab Prem Ki Gazap Kahani, which I shot simultaneously with Wake Up Sid. And which I, at that time, was looking down upon.

Because Wake Up Sid was this cool film with young filmmakers. And, you know, young 80s with walkie talkies. And Ajab Prem Ki Gazap Kahani was directed by Rajkumar Santoshi.

He's a very, very prolific director. But all the assistant directors were older than him. But today, I have so much of understanding of what the effect of that film is more than Wake Up Sid.

So, he was proud of Ajab Prem Ki Gazap Kahani. And there was another political film I did called Rajneeti. I love that movie.

Also, I guess because these were big hits. So, that's why he also liked them. And then right after that, I remember when he saw Rockstar and all, he called me and said, I don't think he got that film.

When he saw Barfi, he said, Yeah, you do good acting. But, you know, do some more popular movies. Jawani Diwani, he didn't understand.

But he understood the success of it. So, he was very happy. And then I guess when he saw Sanju, he was very happy.

These are the films he liked. I guess the commercial success were films. I unfortunately did a very bad film with my parents called Besharam.

We all threw a part of it. But it was really a bad film. So, that was not a good experience.

[Speaker 2] (1:12:10 - 1:12:13)

Whose opinion matters the most when a movie comes out?

[Speaker 1] (1:12:15 - 1:12:51)

See, I always believe my mother is my biggest fan. So, she would always like everything that I do. My father was a little bit…

He became too cliché, his opinion. To a point where he was so scared to watch my films. I did a film called Tamasha with Imtiaz Ali.

He didn't watch it because he thought it was too pseudo. He was like, instead of me giving my opinion, let me not watch these pseudo films. So, that kind of fear was always there about what he would think about a movie.

But no, I think an audience's reaction has always been. Because it's… See, I'm in an industry or an occupation where the result is…

There is an immediate result.

[Speaker 2] (1:12:52 - 1:12:52)

Correct.

[Speaker 1] (1:12:52 - 1:12:53)

You know, you do a film and there's a result.

[Speaker 2] (1:12:54 - 1:12:54)

It's a hit or a flop.

[Speaker 1] (1:12:54 - 1:13:17)

It's a hit or a flop. Like I've done a film called Rocket Singh, Salesman of the Year. Which was a big disaster.

There are many people who come now and say, oh, that was such a wonderful film. But the audience didn't like it. And audience is king.

If the audience doesn't like something, it means there's something wrong in the film. Otherwise, there's no reason for them not to watch your film. So, I think the audience is validation.

It took me time to realize that. But it's their validation or their opinion which matters the most to me.

[Speaker 2] (1:13:18 - 1:13:19)

So, how many films done now?

[Speaker 1] (1:13:20 - 1:13:35)

I've been working since 16 years. And I've had Animal, I think was my 20th release. So, which is not a lot of movies.

I should have been on my 40th film. But most of my films take a lot of time. So, 20 films in 16 years.

[Speaker 2] (1:13:36 - 1:13:56)

They say whenever you get a lot of a good thing, something else goes away. Something bad also happens. Successful in professional life.

I think you're at some kind of a peak today, right? Like a bunch of stuff you've done has worked. What has gone away?

It's come at the cost of what?

[Speaker 1] (1:13:57 - 1:14:44)

See, the thing is, I'm in this, in a way, in a service industry. I'm providing entertainment. And being in that industry, I take it as an honor and not sacrifice.

So, I look at it that way. I've sacrificed childhood friends. I've sacrificed home life.

I've sacrificed a life. I don't have a life. I'm on a movie set or I'm preparing for a movie.

I'm not saying pre my daughter's birth. That was my life. But it doesn't feel like a sacrifice because I genuinely love what I do.

I love being on a set. I love acting. I love telling a story.

I'm sure there have been a lot of sacrifices. But it doesn't feel like a sacrifice. Because if I had to go back, I would still choose the same way.

[Speaker 2] (1:14:45 - 1:14:59)

What does it mean to be a superstar? When you go somewhere and you see the reaction that you get, what does it do? Not the superficial thought.

But deep, deep down, what does it do for you? And what will happen if it goes away?

[Speaker 1] (1:15:01 - 1:16:26)

Of course, it's the greatest feeling in the world, you know. And you get love. You're receiving love.

You're receiving love from people who you don't know. You know, they look at you and they smile at you and their eyes light up. And that feeling is amazing.

But I can't get too attached to it. And this, of course, I've realized very early on. Because I grew up in a film family.

And I've seen so much of successful people. But at the same time, I've seen so many failures. My family has generations of successful actors and failed actors.

So, I know why the people fail. I studied it, you know, from a very young age. I was noticing everything.

I was noticing my father that he didn't like getting bothered. And if a fan came to ask him for an autograph or a picture, he very rudely turned to them and said, no, I'm not interested in doing that. And I always, sitting on the other side of the table, looked at that fan's face.

And that fan used to look at my father with so much of disdain and disappointment. That I was like, listen, I don't think I have the ability to say no to somebody. If somebody wants to take a picture with me or take an autograph, I'll be more than happy to do it.

So, I don't take this job for granted. I know what success is. I know what failure is.

I'm very balanced about it. Anyways, the person I am, I've never felt an extreme high. And I don't feel extreme lows.

So, if it's a successful film, it's more like, bach gaye, till the next one comes. And if it's a failure, like shit, let's try harder again. It's been quite balanced that way.

[Speaker 2] (1:16:27 - 1:16:35)

If you had to say your top, this helps me get to know you so much more as a person, your top two highs of life and lows of life?

[Speaker 1] (1:16:36 - 1:16:46)

Oh, my daughter's birth. Top second would be, I mean my life, you're saying.

[Speaker 2] (1:16:46 - 1:16:48)

What are you feeling, daughter's birth?

[Speaker 1] (1:16:49 - 1:17:26)

You know, till the time she was born when Anu was pregnant, you're imagining it, right? You don't know what the feeling is. She could feel it because baby's in her.

But when she was born and I was given, I was like, first thing, the doctor came and gave me Raha. It's not, you can't describe it. But if I had to describe it, it's like somebody's kind of taken your heart out and just put it in your hand.

You know, it's so, it's instant. It's the love of your life. Like, oh, it's too good.

Yeah, it's too good. Never felt that, never feel, never will feel that about anything or anybody in my life.

[Speaker 2] (1:17:26 - 1:17:35)

Does the mother and father feel about it differently? People say that the mother is connected at birth. The father takes six months, 12 months to feel something.

[Speaker 1] (1:17:35 - 1:18:34)

Yeah, I think Raha considers Alia as a part of her. So, she doesn't consider Alia as another human. Like, they both are one.

But like, with me, she looks for like, the fun and the laughter and flirting. We are flirting all the time. Me and my daughter.

So, that was my top moment. And I think the first moment would be, again, it's a little bit of a, when I got first form of attention, was when I scored a goal for my under 14 tournament for school. And when you score a goal, your name used to come in the newspaper.

In Times of India. All the inter-school matches. Bombay Scottish.

Bombay Scottish. And our team was really good. We won a couple of cups.

We also played state and all. So, that was a very big moment. And my mother made a cutting and I still kept it with her.

But these two moments come to mind. Lows? What about yours?

Highest moments.

[Speaker 2] (1:18:38 - 1:18:40)

The lows are coming more easily than the highs. I don't know why.

[Speaker 1] (1:18:41 - 1:18:43)

We'll get to lows. But if you had to choose two highs.

[Speaker 2] (1:18:44 - 1:18:45)

I'm just getting a lot of lows.

[Speaker 1] (1:18:45 - 1:18:48)

I don't know why. Okay, let's address the lows. Let's wait for the highs to come.

[Speaker 2] (1:18:49 - 1:19:00)

Lows were. Guilt around dad. Recently brother's thing.

A little bit of a.

[Speaker 1] (1:19:00 - 1:19:01)

Have you faced failure?

[Speaker 2] (1:19:02 - 1:19:12)

Yeah, yeah. Like, the life of an investor bar trader. Is the life where you fail 49 times out of 100.

[Speaker 1] (1:19:12 - 1:19:15)

Or failure in a way that, okay, I don't think I'll be able to come back from this.

[Speaker 2] (1:19:18 - 1:19:58)

Not in the recent past. But. Yeah, yeah, I've gone like.

So when you're a trader and you're starting off. Like you start with a small amount of money. You trade.

You trade like mad, right? Like you buy way out of the money options. If you don't have enough capital to do trading another way.

I'm talking like 19, 20 years ago now. You build up and you build up enough of a corpus over. One year, two years, three years.

And then you lose it all in one day. But you go bust. I've had that happen a couple of times.

Not in the last. 13, 14 years. But before that.

[Speaker 1] (1:19:59 - 1:20:04)

So your second low point. I'm regarding your brother and your father's.

[Speaker 2] (1:20:04 - 1:20:07)

Yeah, dog, I think. My dog passed away.

[Speaker 1] (1:20:07 - 1:20:08)

What breed was he?

[Speaker 2] (1:20:08 - 1:20:25)

Boxer. What was his name? Hobbs.

He was with us for 11 years. Hobbs. H-O-B-B-E-S.

H-O-B-B-E-S. Hobbs and Calvin and Hobbs. Like the comics.

But he was not like a dog. He was, I don't know how to describe him. But he emoted.

He knew.

[Speaker 1] (1:20:25 - 1:20:27)

This is when you were living with your parents.

[Speaker 2] (1:20:27 - 1:20:34)

This is when I used to go on and off. See my parents. I was not living with them.

But I would see them maybe every Sunday.

[Speaker 1] (1:20:34 - 1:20:35)

And still you felt so much of attachment.

[Speaker 2] (1:20:36 - 1:20:36)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (1:20:36 - 1:20:40)

The dog was with them. Yeah, the dog was with them. That's crazy.

Yeah. It doesn't make sense though.

[Speaker 2] (1:20:42 - 1:20:58)

There's something about that dog. He was not a dog. He was like.

Hope. No, he was just like. He knew what you were feeling.

Like boxers have that sad face. You know, they never like. They have that droopy mouth thing happening.

And they have those big eyes.

[Speaker 1] (1:20:58 - 1:20:59)

You have a sad face.

[Speaker 2] (1:20:59 - 1:21:02)

Yeah. Good way or bad?

[Speaker 1] (1:21:02 - 1:21:03)

People say I have a sad face.

[Speaker 2] (1:21:04 - 1:22:31)

Yeah, but there was something about him. Even now in my office, in my cabin. I have his picture.

Because I don't know. Sometimes you come across dogs who are not dogs. Low point.

I think when I go all in on a certain company. I'm okay if it succeeds or fails. But if I feel like there has been misrepresentation of some kind.

And I have allowed for myself to get. Swindled is a harsh word. But carried away.

That troubles me. Relationships are hard. Breakups are worse.

I feel like one or two breakups are right up there. It's hard when you're with somebody. And you share so much love.

And after a point if they were to be angry. I think that anger is tough to reason with. Those have been hard.

Yeah, I feel like whatever I cannot. Whatever I feel like I could control. I had some power over.

Or I could control my interaction with that event. And I didn't do something about it. Those are the lows.

Things that I can't control at all. I'm not sure.

[Speaker 1] (1:22:31 - 1:22:50)

It's not in your control. Interesting. My lows would be a passing of my father.

And similar. And second would be a heartbreak in one relationship of mine. So two of that.

There are many. But that's what comes to mind. Did you get your high points yet?

[Speaker 2] (1:22:50 - 1:23:22)

No. Come on, high point. I have a very pessimistic persona in life.

I rehash my flaws in my mind a lot more than the pluses in my mind. Like I'm my worst critic to such an extent. That when I've failed at something is significantly more vivid in my memory.

Than when I've succeeded at something. Makes sense. Yeah.

In a way, it should be that way.

[Speaker 1] (1:23:23 - 1:23:24)

If you want growth.

[Speaker 2] (1:23:26 - 1:23:29)

It's conducive to growth. I don't know if it's conducive to mental well-being overall.

[Speaker 1] (1:23:30 - 1:23:31)

So you're into tattoos?

[Speaker 2] (1:23:32 - 1:23:36)

Little bit. Like one or two. What does it say?

Shalom. Peace in Hebrew.

[Speaker 1] (1:23:36 - 1:23:37)

So you just have one tattoo?

[Speaker 2] (1:23:38 - 1:24:00)

This says, be here now. A book I read. I had this tendency in life to procrastinate a lot.

I would be like, what will happen in 10 years? What will happen in 15 years? There's this author

called Ram Das.

He wrote a book about saying, live today. And not in the tomorrow or the yesterday. And at that point, it resonated with me a fair bit.

[Speaker 1] (1:24:01 - 1:24:02)

And I got this thing.

[Speaker 2] (1:24:02 - 1:24:02)

Will you have any?

[Speaker 1] (1:24:03 - 1:24:09)

I just got one for my daughter. I always wanted it but never found anything meaningful.

[Speaker 2] (1:24:10 - 1:24:22)

What would you do if you weren't afraid? If I? Weren't afraid of anything.

No fear whatsoever of judgment, society, family. All of that.

[Speaker 1] (1:24:22 - 1:24:55)

So you're saying show a version of yourself that you are afraid of. Something about you. I don't know man.

I don't know what my insecurities are also. Like, will I be in a lot of pain and anguish if my movies stop doing well and I don't get opportunities? Money has never been a driving force.

I really go by this one line I read. I think it was GK Krishnamurthy had said it.

[Speaker 2] (1:24:55 - 1:24:55)

Jiddu.

[Speaker 1] (1:24:57 - 1:25:25)

Jiddu? Jiddu Krishnamurthy. Jiddu Krishnamurthy had said.

I don't know the exact code but it goes something like, you see the reason why I'm happy is that I don't mind what happens. So I don't mind. Like if I'm in pain, if I'm feeling sad, I will feel sad.

And I don't question it. I'll go through the beats of it. If I'm happy, I'll go through the beats of it.

So I don't mind it. It's fine. And I really believe in that philosophy.

[Speaker 2] (1:25:26 - 1:25:32)

Jiddu is brilliant by the way. I love him. Do you feel you live a life of contradiction like he speaks of?

[Speaker 1] (1:25:33 - 1:25:34)

Of course, we all do.

[Speaker 2] (1:25:34 - 1:25:36)

What is the contradiction in your life?

[Speaker 1] (1:25:36 - 1:25:59)

Especially when you're in a marriage. You know, you have to let go of your personality. You know, I'm sure she is also letting go of her personality.

We are kind of adjusting to each other. Trying to make it livable for each other. Any marriage is doing that.

So you have to let go. And you have to adjust. And you have to sacrifice facets of it.

Because it's impossible for two people to like each other the way they are.

[Speaker 2] (1:26:00 - 1:26:16)

So what is the ultimate drive in life right now? If you were to be given a wish unrelated to family. A professional wish?

A professional or a personal wish unrelated to family. If Ranbir today can wish for one thing, what would it be?

[Speaker 1] (1:26:16 - 1:26:23)

I'll wish for my father to come back. So I can spend more time with him. Speak to him.

Have conversations with him.

[Speaker 2] (1:26:23 - 1:26:33)

Do your parents, like does your dad show up in your life? In your personality? Like do you often do something and feel like this is so like my dad?

[Speaker 1] (1:26:34 - 1:26:56)

Yeah, I think so. Now I'm feeling that. You know.

Certain things like how he used to yawn, I yawn. He makes a certain sound. So there are a lot of things that I started believing that I emulate him.

But my personality is more like my mother's. You know, she's been someone who's very calm and happy and you know. So it's more like her.

Who are your friends?

[Speaker 2] (1:26:56 - 1:26:58)

Like if you were to name your three, four best friends.

[Speaker 1] (1:26:59 - 1:27:44)

I have two best friends. One is a new one, Ayaan, who I met during Wake Up Sid. And there's another guy called Rohit Dhawan.

Who is David Dhawan's son, Varun Dhawan's brother. He's a director himself. He's a close friend of mine.

So Rohit is that guy who I call to have mindless conversations with. Ayaan is a little bit of a moral compass. You know, we both have certain ideologies and a vision for what we need to do as filmmakers or actors.

And we share that philosophy. So we're kind of in ways pushing each other to reach that. You know, if something's doing anything wrong, make sure you say it like it is.

And don't pussyfoot it.

[Speaker 2] (1:27:45 - 1:27:47)

And what is your ideology? Ranbir's ideology of life?

[Speaker 1] (1:27:51 - 1:29:00)

I think honest, good work. Original. And I think it's misconstrued here.

But acting and making a movie takes a lot of effort. It's not just glamorous. It's not just driving a sports car or romancing a heroine.

It's a lot of hard work. So to continuously do that for a long period of time, it's very hard. I know Mr. Aamir Khan. When I meet him now, I met him two years back and he was in tears. So what happened? He's like, I've spent 30 years of my life and my only relationship I have is with my audience.

I don't have a relationship with my children. I don't have a relationship with my mother. With his

ex-wife, who was his wife then.

And that's what this profession takes. You have to give it all. So the endeavor is also to kind of balance a real life with your real life.

And not get swayed by this ambition. I don't want to get swayed by ambition.

[Speaker 2] (1:29:01 - 1:29:12)

Right. Of the three Khans, I'm guessing there's significantly senior. What do you think, if you had to pick one thing from each of them, what would you pick?

[Speaker 1] (1:29:13 - 1:29:42)

Interesting question. We'll start with Aamir Khan. His work ethic, I've seen him at work.

And it's a lot of work. His work ethic is just amazing. Labor, you know, he's laborious and he does the work.

Shah Rukh Khan for his giving nature. He'll talk to you and he will make you feel like you're the only person in the world.

[Speaker 2] (1:29:42 - 1:29:42)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (1:29:42 - 1:29:49)

And I've seen him do that to every person he speaks to. And initially, I tried doing it. It's not possible.

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:29:49 - 1:29:56)

What is he doing? What is he capturing that is working so well? Because I feel the same way.

Like I feel like…

[Speaker 1] (1:29:56 - 1:29:59)

He's giving. And when you're giving, people take. They receive.

[Speaker 2] (1:30:00 - 1:30:01)

Giving in terms of attention?

[Speaker 1] (1:30:01 - 1:30:41)

He's giving. He's giving himself. This is a piece of me.

And even if he's not there, he's still giving. And audiences that effort. But Shah Rukh Khan, after so many years, where he is in life to still give.

It's really admirable. And Salman Khan for his… A lot of things I admire about Salman Khan, actually.

I don't speak about it often. There is a mischievous, childlike quality in Salman, which is not one of them. A lot of people who don't know him can get confused that he is trying to bully you or something.

But he's got a childlike quality. Thank you. It's an interesting bottle.

This is…

[Speaker 2] (1:30:41 - 1:30:45)

Camel Black. What is that? Camel Black Shoot.

It's a bottle of…

[Speaker 1] (1:30:46 - 1:30:47)

Oh, the brand Camel Black.

[Speaker 2] (1:30:50 - 1:31:01)

They make decent bottles. If you had to term this chapter of your life something. Like these two years of your life.

What would the chapter be called?

[Speaker 1] (1:31:03 - 1:31:13)

Wow. Chapter. Do you have an answer for yourself?

What next? What next? So you say what next is because it's not enough?

[Speaker 2] (1:31:15 - 1:31:16)

Because I feel like…

[Speaker 1] (1:31:16 - 1:31:23)

And I need more. I need to achieve more. I need to spread my wings wider.

I need to reach out more.

[Speaker 2] (1:31:24 - 1:32:00)

I feel like I'm transitioning from a very stock market heavy role. To a very longer term investor kind of role. I'm actually enjoying that.

Like each time I invest in a new industry today. It could be any industry, right? It could be like clothes.

It could be consumer. It could be coffee. It could be manufacturing.

It could be EV. It gives me a high to walk into a completely new field where I know nothing. And then be taught.

[Speaker 1] (1:32:02 - 1:32:06)

When you give somebody a check, do you feel arrogant about it?

[Speaker 2] (1:32:06 - 1:32:06)

No, no.

[Speaker 1] (1:32:06 - 1:32:07)

You don't feel arrogant?

[Speaker 2] (1:32:07 - 1:32:17)

Not at all. The opposite. I feel like once somebody has taken a check, they have the right to be arrogant.

Which is often the case. Because they're nice to you.

[Speaker 1] (1:32:17 - 1:32:21)

It is the case. Nikhil Garman is investing in the company. It is a big deal for them.

[Speaker 2] (1:32:21 - 1:33:10)

Also very consciously people are nicer to you before they get funded. Not after. Right?

But that process of working with new industries I find very exhilarating, right? And deep down I have learned one fact of my life. Is learning alleviates anxiety and validates me.

There's something about learning. Like I might not be paying attention to the book in my hand. I might not be capturing any of what it says.

But having it in front of my face for an hour before I go to bed makes me feel better about myself. It's not the book. It's the act of even attempting to learn alleviates anxiety.

[Speaker 1] (1:33:11 - 1:33:14)

Pratikya. Do you spend your money?

[Speaker 2] (1:33:15 - 1:33:16)

Yeah. I spend money.

[Speaker 1] (1:33:16 - 1:33:17)

Like holidays and travel?

[Speaker 2] (1:33:17 - 1:33:19)

Yeah, holidays, travel, things.

[Speaker 1] (1:33:19 - 1:33:20)

Are you into cars, properties?

[Speaker 2] (1:33:20 - 1:33:29)

Not. See, I'm not a saint or anything like that. Properties, no.

I rent this house. I rent my house in Bangalore.

[Speaker 1] (1:33:29 - 1:33:30)

You don't believe in investing?

[Speaker 2] (1:33:31 - 1:33:47)

I'm not a fan. I feel like rental yields on residential real estate in India are 3%. If I'm able to utilize a property at 3% it would be far-fetched for me.

I mean the rate of borrowing in society today is 10-11%.

[Speaker 1] (1:33:47 - 1:33:52)

Even after you made so much of money? It's... What are you going to do with so much money after you die?

[Speaker 2] (1:33:53 - 1:34:00)

It's not that. I just feel like I'm getting a deal when I'm renting versus buying. I feel like...

[Speaker 1] (1:34:00 - 1:34:04)

There's no emotional thing that I want to own a home? No. No, never.

[Speaker 2] (1:34:05 - 1:34:06)

Cars, no. Like I have cars.

[Speaker 1] (1:34:07 - 1:34:08)

Are you fond of cars, like sports cars?

[Speaker 2] (1:34:09 - 1:34:24)

I don't have any Ferraris or Lamborghinis or any of that. But I have nice cars. I have like whatever, BMW, Merc, stuff like that.

But I don't have... Let me put it this way. I don't have anything that somebody on the street would turn around and take pictures of.

[Speaker 1] (1:34:24 - 1:34:32)

Are you into art? Yeah. Indian art?

Indian art. Favourite Indian artist? Sousa.

Sousa. There was Sousa here? No.

[Speaker 2] (1:34:33 - 1:34:34)

Don't have much art here.

[Speaker 1] (1:34:35 - 1:34:40)

Little bit more in Bangalore. Okay, who else? I'm not talking about the masters if you're talking about like the new artists.

[Speaker 2] (1:34:40 - 1:34:44)

There's a new guy I have outside called Anjay Neelu Gundu. Okay.

[Speaker 1] (1:34:45 - 1:34:45)

African?

[Speaker 2] (1:34:45 - 1:34:53)

No, no, Indian. From Hyderabad, he used to paint footpaths and signboards. Somebody sent him to art school and now he's become like a really big artist.

[Speaker 1] (1:34:53 - 1:34:53)

What's his name again?

[Speaker 2] (1:34:54 - 1:35:39)

Anjay Neelu Gundu. I like Pawel, the Polish guy. I have a whole bunch of his.

I have like 20 paintings of his here. Nice. I like Vaikuntham a little bit.

I like Gaitonde. I like Jamini Roy. I like Taibh Mehta.

Indian artists I think are growing. I think the Indian art scene has slightly lagged behind because we always painted in 2D in a way. Western art was more three-dimensional in nature.

But I think a lot of new people are really picking up. I'd love to do something in art. I mean, I don't know what.

[Speaker 1] (1:35:40 - 1:35:40)

Are you envious about anything?

[Speaker 2] (1:35:42 - 1:35:49)

I'm not envious about anything in particular. But I know how big a part envy has played in my own life.

[Speaker 1] (1:35:50 - 1:35:52)

Okay. Yeah, yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:35:52 - 1:35:53)

I feel like…

[Speaker 1] (1:35:53 - 1:35:53)

Who are you envious about?

[Speaker 2] (1:35:54 - 1:36:32)

Of circumstances. Young, can't afford a certain thing, want to work doubly hard in order to obtain that is. At the bottom of it, like the core feeling is envy.

It's jealousy. It's insecurity. I think society misrepresents insecurity to be a bad thing.

Insecurity, in my opinion, leading to inaction is a bad thing. Insecurity leading to action is generally conducive to a world governed by capitalism for sure. What are you insecure about today?

[Speaker 1] (1:36:33 - 1:37:29)

See, I'm not insecure about my work. You know, I don't know if that's arrogance, if it's too much of self-confidence, if it's in the place I'm in in my life, where I am. So, I don't feel insecure about it.

Now, maybe tomorrow if everything snaps away from me, I can't imagine that. I do have a lot of faith in my art. It's been a while since I've been insecure, you know.

I don't like feel insecure if like, if I see Alia romancing another guy on screen. Maybe like 10 years back, I would feel that. But I've grown up.

I've understood life a bit. I'm really interested to know about your relationship with our Prime Minister. Like, are you friendly with him?

Can you like pick up the phone and call him?

[Speaker 2] (1:37:30 - 1:37:30)

No.

[Speaker 1] (1:37:30 - 1:37:31)

Somebody told you not to say anything?

[Speaker 2] (1:37:32 - 1:37:40)

No. Can I pick up the phone and call him? No.

Have I had the privilege of… He's very fond of you. I don't know about that.

[Speaker 1] (1:37:41 - 1:37:45)

I feel like… That's what we hear about. He's very fond of what you've done, what you've achieved.

[Speaker 2] (1:37:46 - 1:38:17)

I don't know. I feel like I've had the privilege of being around him at a couple of events. And I think people read into that.

But like, I respect him. I admire him. And I feel like…

I'll give you a story. Once we were in the US. There was three, four of us with him.

Two years back. Yeah, one year back or something like that. And we were in Washington for three, four days.

[Speaker 1] (1:38:18 - 1:38:19)

And… You were traveling with him?

[Speaker 2] (1:38:19 - 1:39:20)

No, no. I went there on my own. But he was there.

And he would do a speaking session with us in a room with some American businessmen and all of that at 8 a.m. in the morning. He would go give a speech somewhere at 11 a.m. Then he would go sit in like the vice president something at 1 p.m., 2 p.m. He would do something else at 4 p.m. Something else at 7 p.m. Something else at 11 p.m. And at 8, 9 in the evening, I was out. Like, you know, I was like, okay, I'm tired.

After two days, I'm feeling sick. He was then going to Egypt to do the same thing all over again. I think his energy at his age and…

There's a lot to learn. I feel like there's a lot to learn from everybody. And there is definitely so much to learn from him.

And I feel like privileged to have had…

[Speaker 1] (1:39:22 - 1:39:23)

Cinema is such close quarters.

[Speaker 2] (1:39:23 - 1:39:29)

Yeah, yeah. There's a lot to learn from him. But no, I don't think he would pick up my phone.

Nor do I have his phone number.

[Speaker 1] (1:39:29 - 1:39:30)

Should we try?

[Speaker 2] (1:39:30 - 1:39:49)

Nor is there any such kind of a thing, no. Yeah, I wish… Honestly, I wish there were.

But there isn't. The leader of the country and I am just me. What about you?

What do you think of politics?

[Speaker 1] (1:39:49 - 1:40:49)

What do I think about politics? I don't really need to think much. But I know that when I met the prime minister, all of us went to meet him four or five years back.

A couple of young actors and directors. Because you see him on television. You see how he talks.

He's a great orator. But I remember the moment that we were sitting and he walked in. And he got this magnetic charm about himself.

And he came and he sat down. And he spoke to each person something so personal. Like my father was going through treatment that time.

So he was asking how the treatment is going. And what's happening and all of that. He was talking to Alia about something else.

Vicky Kaushal about something else. Karan Johar about… Everything was very personal.

And that kind of effort. You see in great men. When they put that effort.

He doesn't need to. We spoke with Shah Rukh Khan. And the many.

The many achievers who put in that effort. And that says a lot about that person.

[Speaker 2] (1:40:49 - 1:41:01)

Yeah, he has aura for sure. And it's a tough job being a politician. Not just him.

I think for every politician out there, we see one side of it. But I think to be in their shoes is very hard.

[Speaker 1] (1:41:01 - 1:41:03)

It's very hard. Super hard, man.

[Speaker 2] (1:41:04 - 1:41:10)

I would not give up my shoes to be in those shoes. That's why when you asked me earlier

politics, I said no chance. I like my shoes.

[Speaker 1] (1:41:11 - 1:41:14)

Is there a reason that you have your initials on your slippers?

[Speaker 2] (1:41:15 - 1:41:48)

Yeah. So like I was telling you earlier, I feel like craftsmanship, Indian brands making it big abroad. I'm being like totally for that.

This is a local Indian brand which has access to the best kind of leather, the best kind of craftsmanship you can find. They cost maybe like 10,000 bucks to make. They feel.

[Speaker 1] (1:41:48 - 1:41:50)

10,000 rupees? Yeah. Is that a lot?

[Speaker 2] (1:41:50 - 1:41:51)

No, it's not.

[Speaker 1] (1:41:52 - 1:41:53)

Like a cost price of a...

[Speaker 2] (1:41:53 - 1:42:01)

No, no. They sell it to me for that much. I don't know how much they're actually...

But they feel better than a foreign brand like Gucci or LV.

[Speaker 1] (1:42:01 - 1:42:01)

Really?

[Speaker 2] (1:42:02 - 1:42:07)

And you can actually feel the leather and compare. I feel like there are so many options like this in India.

[Speaker 1] (1:42:08 - 1:42:09)

This is already in market?

[Speaker 2] (1:42:10 - 1:42:13)

Yeah. What's it called? This is called Curo.

C-U-E-R-O.

[Speaker 1] (1:42:13 - 1:42:14)

And where is the brand from?

[Speaker 2] (1:42:15 - 1:42:16)

You know how I found them? On Instagram.

[Speaker 1] (1:42:17 - 1:42:19)

Like it just sponsored thinking?

[Speaker 2] (1:42:19 - 1:42:23)

Independent Indian shoemakers. They didn't even make chappals.

[Speaker 1] (1:42:23 - 1:42:28)

So, Instagram is kind of listening to us. So, it will pop up, right? So, I don't need to worry.

[Speaker 2] (1:42:28 - 1:42:37)

But I think this is the way forward. Like Sabko, the coffee brand. I just invested in them.

I feel like their coffee is better than other countries' coffee. Have you tried?

[Speaker 1] (1:42:37 - 1:42:38)

Yeah, of course.

[Speaker 2] (1:42:38 - 1:43:06)

But I think Sabko has potential outside. I feel like these guys have potential. There's a brand I'm looking at.

Haven't invested yet. Called 1111. Which makes shirts using kantara, bandhgani, crazy good designs.

Again, Indian independent. And there are so many of these blossoming brands. I feel like it's such an easy switch.

What novelty are you getting buying a Gucci t-shirt or a Balenciaga shoe?

[Speaker 1] (1:43:07 - 1:43:07)

Society.

[Speaker 2] (1:43:08 - 1:43:43)

Yeah. And here like, you know, somebody has spent 20 hours using their hand in making something. The fabric is significantly better.

The leather is significantly better. The coffee is significantly better. I feel like if we all were to switch a little bit like that, net-net result would come back and help us in our own way.

Because you will build something, right? You'll start a sneaker brand tomorrow. I'll start something.

You'll buy more of me. I'll buy more of you. Net-net helps the ecosystem.

Yeah. So, the chappal is a product of that.

[Speaker 1] (1:43:45 - 1:43:49)

And I don't think it's... What are the three health hacks that you've discovered all these years that you think is really helpful?

[Speaker 2] (1:43:49 - 1:43:51)

I think sleep. Sleep is the number one.

[Speaker 1] (1:43:51 - 1:43:54)

And you're not an afternoon napper. Can you nap in the afternoon?

[Speaker 2] (1:43:55 - 1:44:15)

I can if I try, I'm sure. But it doesn't happen very often. I try and break my day up in a way that 8, 8.30 in the morning till 3.34 I'm stuck with stock markets. I typically try and go to the gym at 4. Find a workout till 5. And then do meetings and the investing stuff.

[Speaker 1] (1:44:16 - 1:44:18)

So, you have a long day of work.

[Speaker 2] (1:44:19 - 1:44:21)

But it doesn't feel like that. A lot of people...

[Speaker 1] (1:44:21 - 1:44:24)

So, when you say you're 7 hours in the stock market, so you're just in front of TV or on the

phone?

[Speaker 2] (1:44:24 - 1:44:26)

In front of computers. Not on the phone.

[Speaker 1] (1:44:26 - 1:44:27)

So, you're not on the phone? No.

[Speaker 2] (1:44:27 - 1:44:30)

Most of my conversations with my colleagues is on chat.

[Speaker 1] (1:44:31 - 1:44:32)

Okay. What app do you use?

[Speaker 2] (1:44:32 - 1:44:33)

Google.

[Speaker 1] (1:44:33 - 1:44:34)

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:44:34 - 1:44:38)

So, we use Google Mail, Google Drive, Google Chat. Everything's on Google.

[Speaker 1] (1:44:38 - 1:44:40)

Okay. So, sleep is one. Then?

[Speaker 2] (1:44:41 - 1:44:43)

What am I having actively? Omega 3.

[Speaker 1] (1:44:43 - 1:44:44)

Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:44:44 - 1:44:48)

Everybody seems to think there is something in that. And...

[Speaker 1] (1:44:48 - 1:44:50)

Do you take cold showers? Ice baths?

[Speaker 2] (1:44:50 - 1:45:01)

I want to. I tried it like... I'm trying to like put ice by ice.

Put it in the bathtub and then try it. But I'm lasting like 40 seconds or something.

[Speaker 1] (1:45:01 - 1:45:03)

That's not bad. Have you done cryotherapy?

[Speaker 2] (1:45:03 - 1:45:06)

I've tried. You must work out like proper, proper.

[Speaker 1] (1:45:06 - 1:46:33)

You know, I've still... Because of this new project that I'm going to start soon, I've really changed... ...my style of workout. Because before it was like dumbbells and pushing and chest press and... ...you know, protein and all of that. I'm working with this really interesting trainer.

He's from Korea. His name is Nam. His name is Nam.

And he's really holistically changed my perception of training. I train with him three hours a day. In the morning, I do mobility and stretching and cardio.

From 11 to 12. I'll sleep in the afternoon for an hour. And then I'll train from 5 to 7.

And that's usually strength. But I'm doing such new things. And which has nothing to do with machines or weights.

You know, it's bodyweight. It's a lot of pull-ups, a lot of squats, a lot of deadlifts. That's the only weight I use.

Otherwise, a lot of new style of training. You know, handstands, headstands. So, I'm enjoying it.

You know, I'm bored of just pumping. Three hours a day is a lot. It is a lot.

But I'm doing it because I'm preparing for a role. What is the role? They haven't announced the film yet.

So, I don't want to say it. But it is definitely the most challenging part that I could get. It requires a lot of...

It requires another level of... I wouldn't say method, but preparation. Which I've been preparing

actually since the last seven months.

I haven't shot a movie since eight months actually. So, this has been like a paternity leave for me.

[Speaker 2] (1:46:34 - 1:46:41)

Who do you think... If you were to categorize somebody as competition, you really look up to in Bollywood, who would it be?

[Speaker 1] (1:46:41 - 1:47:19)

So, my age group are below me, right? I wouldn't say the Khans or anything like that. Though when I started, I was like Amitabh Bachchan is my competition.

Why should I say, you know, the new guys? They're such fine actors. I like Vicky Kaushal's work a lot.

Ranveer Singh. Yeah, you know, it's the opportunity and the film. I've realized that.

You have an actor which you don't quite appreciate right now. But him in a right film at the right time will just change it for you. But as of right now, two actors that I really like is Vicky Kaushal, Ranveer Singh.

And I like Karthik also. You know, I think Karthik has something very charming on screen. You know, he's got a charming personality.

[Speaker 2] (1:47:19 - 1:47:29)

Is it tough to be in a profession where you in a way get the result of a lot of work on one particular day? Like you put in one year of work, two years of work.

[Speaker 1] (1:47:29 - 1:48:06)

And it's a span of ten seconds, right? They'll say, what a bad film it is. Yeah.

You know, waste of time and they're like, f**k, superb film. On to life. You know, it's just that.

So, that's why I say always that you're saved and on to the next. Because you cannot take that seriously. It's a lot of work.

For one year, we are making this film like we are saving the world. You know, it's that kind of intention. But the result is, and I've seen it break people.

Like being a part of movies is an industry of many heartbreaks. Because your heart is, it's what three or four films work in a year.

[Speaker 2] (1:48:06 - 1:48:06)

Right.

[Speaker 1] (1:48:06 - 1:48:09)

And usually one surprise film are the big ones, you know.

[Speaker 2] (1:48:09 - 1:48:11)

Three or four out of 30, 40?

[Speaker 1] (1:48:11 - 1:48:14)

I would say out of 80, you know, 80, 90.

[Speaker 2] (1:48:14 - 1:48:15)

So, 5% success.

[Speaker 1] (1:48:16 - 1:48:23)

Whoever has come into the movies, they always lose money. Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:48:23 - 1:48:27)

Can you make money in movies? Not as an actor, but as a person coming from outside?

[Speaker 1] (1:48:28 - 1:49:01)

I think the new corporate system of financing films and owning IP is also has also been a game changer now because of OTT. Because of social media. So, IP is a big game right now.

As it is everywhere. But yeah, I think if you have the lion's share, if you finance a film, you will make money. But if you're just a producer who's just taking money and making a film, you don't want to make much money.

Right. It's very hard.

[Speaker 2] (1:49:01 - 1:49:07)

Yeah, I feel like I meet so many people who are investing in movies. How many of them actually make money when you ask them?

[Speaker 1] (1:49:07 - 1:49:08)

It's just a passion thing, you know.

[Speaker 2] (1:49:08 - 1:49:09)

Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (1:49:09 - 1:49:10)

That's what they just want to be part of the movies.

[Speaker 2] (1:49:11 - 1:49:17)

I feel like it's tough to compete with businesses where people are doing it for passion. I believe the same in restaurants. Very hard to make money.

[Speaker 1] (1:49:18 - 1:49:18)

In restaurants. Yeah.

[Speaker 2] (1:49:19 - 1:49:19)

Passion.

[Speaker 1] (1:49:19 - 1:49:55)

Any closing thoughts? This has truly been, you know, it happens to me, you know, sometimes when I'm acting and you're very tired and you give a shot and you've really given something from inside and you're not aware of what you said and you go and you wonder, what did I say? But something has left you in some way.

So you feel a little weak and drowsy. So I'm feeling a little weak and drowsy. I hope you've not spoken rubbish, but I mean, it's really an honor to be around you, to speak to you and you showing so much of interest towards me, my work and my life.

It's been a pleasure. Thank you, man.

[Speaker 2] (1:49:56 - 1:50:12)

Thank you so much for coming. And we'd love to see more of you. We'll figure out how we can do it.

We'll tell you topics that might resonate with you. So we can start the conversation here. But over the years, we'll do a lot more.

Done. Thank you so much.

[Speaker 1] (1:50:13 - 1:50:13)

Thank you.

[Speaker 2] (1:50:13 - 1:50:22)

Thank you, guys. Thank you all for coming. Thanks, all.

We've done three hours. Are you serious? Yeah.

[Speaker 1] (1:50:24 - 1:50:26)

You're like, cut it.